PRIVATE
STUDIO
SYSTEM

FREE GUIDE FOR TATTOO ARTISTS

FROM DM TO DEPOSIT.

The system my studio runs on, every app you'd need to build it yourself, and what it costs in money and hours.

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WHY I WROTE THIS

My studio answers every tattoo request while I'm tattooing, and nothing goes on my calendar without a deposit. This guide shows you how that works, every app you could build it with yourself, and what it costs in money and hours.

Watch it working: nicktylertattoo.com/guide/1

I'm not teaching anyone to tattoo. You already can. This is the business side, the part nobody taught either of us.

Most artists lose bookings in the same three places:

- A request sits in your DMs until the client books someone else.
- A date goes on the calendar with no deposit, and the chair sits empty.
- You type the same confirmations, reminders and aftercare texts all day.

From my own records: 1,500+ tattoo requests through one form, 1,100+ bookings with a deposit on every one, 450+ birthday texts sent for me, and 131 Google reviews.

Here's what's inside:

1. The framework: one request, nine steps, two of them yours.
2. Every feature: how I run it, then the free and paid apps that can do it, with prices checked in October 2026.
3. The do-it-yourself bill: software, texting and card fees, and setup hours.
4. My real client texts and deposit policy, ready to copy.

FROM DM TO DEPOSIT

THE FRAMEWORK

One request moves through nine steps, from the form to a repeat client, and only two of them need you.

Watch it working: nicktylertattoo.com/guide/2

YOUR CLIENT	THE SYSTEM	YOU
1 Sends a request		
	2 Replies and files it	
		3 Approve and size it
	4 Sends your booking link	
5 Pays a deposit to book		
	6 Confirms and reminds	
		7 Do the tattoo
	8 Aftercare and follow-up	
9 Comes back		

One request, from the form to a repeat client. The two gold steps are yours.

Everything in the middle column happens on its own. You approve the request and do the tattoo.

PART 1

GETTING THE REQUEST

Every request lands in one place with everything you need to say yes, and the client hears back in minutes, even while you're tattooing.

Watch it working: nicktylertattoo.com/guide/3

How I run it. One form asks for the idea, placement, size and reference photos, with a checkbox agreeing to my deposit policy. The moment it's sent, the client gets my "request received" text, I get a notice, and the request lands on my board as New. Instagram comments asking about tattoos get the form link by DM.

What you'd need: a form that takes photos, a board to track requests, a texting service plus an automation app for the instant reply, and a comment-to-DM tool. Prices below are US prices from each app's pricing page in October 2026, billed monthly, with the yearly-billing price in parentheses.

The request form

APP	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN THAT DOES IT	CATCH
Tally	Unlimited submissions, 10 MB per photo	Pro, $29 ($24)	Confirmation emails to clients need Pro
Fillout	1,000 responses a month, 20 MB per photo	Starter, $19 ($15)	The free plan shows Fillout's badge
Google Forms	Unlimited responses	Not needed	Clients must sign in to Google to upload photos
Jotform	100 submissions a month, 100 MB of uploads in total	Bronze, $39 ($34)	The free 100 MB fills after 10 to 30 requests' photos
Typeform	10 responses a month, no uploads	Basic, $39 ($28)	The free plan can't take photos

The request board

APP	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN THAT DOES IT	CATCH
Trello	10 boards	Standard, $6 ($5)	Requests need copying in, or an automation app
Notion	Free for one person, 5 MB per upload	Plus, $12 ($10)	Phone photos can top 5 MB

APP	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN THAT DOES IT	CATCH
Airtable	1,000 records, 1 GB of attachments	Team, $24 ($20)	Reference photos fill 1 GB within months
HubSpot	Free CRM, 1,000 contacts	Starter, $20	Texting clients needs a much higher plan

Under every automatic text

An instant reply takes two apps: a texting service to send it, and an automation app to fire it the moment the form comes in.

TEXTING SERVICE	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN THAT DOES IT	CATCH
SimpleTexting	Trial only	500 credits, $39 ($33.20), plus $10 for a local number	Long texts use 2 credits, photo texts 3
Textedly	Trial, 50 texts	Basic, 500 texts, $29	Overage and photo text rates aren't published
EZ Texting	Trial only	Boost, $75 ($60)	The $25 plan caps you at 500 contacts
Quo, formerly OpenPhone	Trial only	Starter, $19 ($15), plus registration	No mass texting; automatic texts need an add-on
Twilio	Pay as you go	$1.15 a month for a number, about 1¢ a text	A developer tool: you build the inbox and automations

Every US business texting number also needs carrier registration: about $4 to $4.50 once for your brand, $15 once for the campaign review, then $1.50 to $10 a month (Twilio's fees). Twilio says that review takes 10 to 15 days (Twilio).

AUTOMATION APP	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN THAT DOES IT	CATCH
Zapier	100 tasks a month, two steps, no waits	Professional, $29.99 ($19.99)	"Text them 2 days later" needs a paid plan
Make	1,000 credits a month, 2 automations	Core, about $10.59 ($9)	Waits over 5 minutes need a workaround

Comment to DM

APP	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN THAT DOES IT	CATCH
Meta Business Suite	Built-in comment-to-message reply	Not needed	One canned reply, no follow-ups
ManyChat	25 active contacts a month	Essential, $17 ($14); Pro, $39 ($29)	Billed by active contacts, so one busy post can bump your plan

PART 2

APPROVE AND BOOK

Nothing goes on my calendar until the deposit is paid, and the client books themselves, so I never chase a deposit.

Watch it working: nicktylertattoo.com/guide/4

How I run it. I read each request and add one tag, Half or Full. That tag texts the client my booking link in my words, set to the right session length. They pick an open date and pay the deposit to hold it. My menu has two sessions: a Half, up to 3 hours with a $150 deposit, and a Full, up to 6 hours with a $250 deposit.

What you'd need: a booking app that takes the deposit at booking, and a card processor behind it. With separate apps, "one tag sends the link" becomes a saved reply you paste, picking the right link each time.

The booking calendar

APP	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN WITH DEPOSITS	CATCH
Square Appointments	Takes deposits, sends text and email reminders	The free plan does it; Plus, $49, adds no-show fees	Online deposits on the free plan cost 3.3% + 30¢
Setmore	Up to 4 users, no deposits	Pro, $12 ($5)	Card fees come on top
Calendly	1 event type, no payments	Standard, $12 ($10)	Built for meetings: one fixed charge per event type
Acuity Scheduling	None	Starter, $20 ($16)	Text reminders start at the $34 plan
Fresha	None	Independent, $19.95	A 20% fee on new clients who find you on its marketplace
GlossGenius	None	Standard, $28 ($24)	Consent forms need the $56 plan
Vagaro	None	Base, $30	$23.99 for the first 6 months, then $30
Bookedin, popular with tattoo artists	50 bookings a month, no payments	Plus, $24 ($19); texts need Pro, $48 ($39)	No e-signed consent forms

APP	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN WITH DEPOSITS	CATCH
Tattoo Studio Pro, built for tattoo studios	None	Solo, $29 ($19.92), every feature	One flat deposit amount for every booking
Porter, built for tattoo studios	None	Artist Essentials, $35	Consent forms need Artist Pro, $65

Card fees

PROCESSOR	ONLINE DEPOSIT	TAP IN PERSON	FEE ON A $250 ONLINE DEPOSIT
Stripe	2.9% + 30¢	2.7% + 5¢	$7.55
Square	3.3% + 30¢ (2.9% + 30¢ on Plus)	2.6% + 15¢	$8.55
PayPal	2.99% + 49¢ by card; 3.49% + 49¢ for guest checkout or a PayPal account	2.29% + 9¢	$7.97 to $9.22

PART 3

BEFORE THE SESSION

The client knows when, where and how to prepare, and I don't type any of it.

Watch it working: nicktylertattoo.com/guide/5

How I run it. The moment the deposit is paid, the client gets a confirmation text with my prep page. The day before, a reminder goes out with the time, the prep page and my consent form. When they sign it, I get a notice, so I know who's ready before they walk in.

What you'd need: a confirmation, a day-before reminder, a prep page, and a consent form clients can sign on their phone. Most booking apps in Part 2 send the confirmation and reminders for you. Text reminders are free on Square Appointments and come with Calendly Standard and Setmore Pro; Acuity and Bookedin charge more for them. A prep page can be a page on your website or a shared doc, for free.

The consent form

APP	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN THAT DOES IT	CATCH
Tattoo Studio Pro Free Forms	Free, no usage limits	Not needed	Made for signing in the studio; you store the PDFs
waivers.tattoo	Your first waivers	Unlimited, $5 ($4.17)	A small vendor, live since 2023
WaiverForever	20 signed waivers a month	Essential, $19, 50 included then 10¢ each	3 templates on Essential
WaiverSign	None	Growth, $19 ($15), 100 a month	Cancel and you lose access, so download them first
Smartwaiver	None	Basic, $22 ($17.50), 100 a month	Keeping records while paused costs $7 a month
Jotform	Signature field included, 100 submissions a month	Bronze, $39 ($34)	The free plan deletes the oldest entries after 500

PART 4

AFTER THE SESSION

The texts that bring clients back go out on their own, long after I've moved on to the next tattoo.

Watch it working: nicktylertattoo.com/guide/6

How I run it. At checkout the deposit comes off the total, and I log the balance on the client's record, cash or card. After the session, the aftercare text goes out with my Google review link. Approved clients who go quiet get a check-in on day 2 and a last one around day 7, and the request closes after 30 days. Every client gets a birthday text from me each year, with an offer to come back.

What you'd need: a way to take the balance, the texting service and automation app from Part 1 for aftercare and check-ins, your review link, and an email tool for birthdays and anything you send your whole client list. Card fees for tapping a card in person are in Part 2.

Your Google review link is free from your Business Profile, and Google prohibits rewarding clients for reviews. If you'd rather pay for review requests, NiceJob sends them by text and email from $75 a month.

Birthdays and emails to past clients

Birthday texts need a birthday question on your form, plus the texting service and automation app. By email, these tools handle a list of about 1,500 past clients:

APP	FREE PLAN	PAID PLAN THAT DOES IT	CATCH
Brevo	300 emails a day, birthday automations	Starter, about $17	On the free plan, one email to 1,500 clients takes 5 days to send
Kit	10,000 subscribers, 1 basic automation	Creator, $39 at 1,000 subscribers ($33), about $59 at 3,000	No simple yearly birthday trigger
MailerLite	250 subscribers, 3 automations	Comfort, about $33 at 2,500 subscribers	The free plan was cut from 1,000 to 250 subscribers
Mailchimp	250 contacts, no automations	Essentials, about $26.50 at 1,500 contacts	Automated flows max out at 4 steps

Win-back texts at 6 and 12 months and a monthly letter to past clients run on the same tools.

PART 5

KEEPING IT RUNNING

Three pieces make the whole thing easy to live with: one inbox, a reply assistant, and one settings page.

Watch it working: nicktylertattoo.com/guide/7

How I run it. Texts, Instagram DMs, Facebook messages and emails land in one inbox. A reply assistant drafts answers to common questions in my voice, and I read and send each one myself. One settings page holds my booking link, deposits and review link, and every message pulls from it, so a new link is one change, not forty.

What you'd need, piece by piece:

- **One inbox.** Meta Business Suite puts Instagram DMs and Facebook messages in one free inbox. Texts and email stay in their own apps, so you check three places.
- **Reply drafts.** An AI assistant can draft replies, but you copy and paste between apps, and it only knows your prices and openings if you tell it each time.
- **One settings page.** With separate apps, your booking link, deposit amounts and review link live inside each app's messages. Change one and you hunt it down everywhere.

AI ASSISTANT	PRICE A MONTH	CATCH
ChatGPT Plus	$20 (Go, $8)	No yearly discount
Claude Pro	$20 ($17)	Usage limits apply
Google AI Plus or Pro	$4.99 or $19.99	Drafts in Gmail; texts and DMs stay copy and paste

All-in-one platforms

These bundle a CRM, forms, a calendar and email into one bill. They cut the logins, not the build: you still write every form, message and automation yourself.

PLATFORM	CHEAPEST PLAN THAT FITS	CATCH
HighLevel	Starter, $97 ($81)	Texting is billed on top: about ¾¢ a text each way, $1.15 a month for a number, plus registration (HighLevel)
HoneyBook	Starter, $36 ($29)	2 request forms and 1 session type; texting is an add-on from $8
Dubsado	Premier, about $55 ($44)	No built-in texting

FROM DM TO DEPOSIT

THE DO-IT-YOURSELF BILL

A setup where the texts go out on their own runs about $180 to $190 a month in software (about $150 to $160 billed yearly), plus card fees and 15 to 25 hours to build. The cheapest setup costs $0 a month, and you type the texts yourself.

PIECE	CHEAPEST SETUP	CONNECTED SETUP
Request form	Tally, $0	Fillout Starter, $19
Request board	Trello, $0	Trello Standard, $6
Texting	Your own phone, $0	SimpleTexting, $39, plus $10 for a number
Texting registration	Not needed	$1.50 to $10, plus about $20 once
Automation	None	Zapier Professional, $29.99
Booking and deposits	Square Appointments, $0	Square Appointments, $0
Consent forms	Tattoo Studio Pro Free Forms, $0	WaiverForever Essential, $19
Birthdays and email	Brevo, $0	Brevo Starter, about $17
Comment to DM	Meta Business Suite, $0	ManyChat Essential, $17
Reply drafts	None	ChatGPT Plus or Claude Pro, $20
Review link	Google, $0	Google, $0
Software a month	**$0**	**About $180 to $190**
Card fees	**3.3% + 30¢ per online deposit**	**3.3% + 30¢ per online deposit**
Accounts to manage	**7**	**10**
Setup, my estimate	**5 to 8 hours**	**15 to 25 hours, plus 10 to 15 days for texting approval**
Each month, my estimate	**About 200 texts typed by hand, 4 to 7 hours**	**1 to 2 hours fixing connections and links**

The hours are my estimates for a solo artist with 30 to 40 bookings a month. Every one of these apps works. The real cost is connecting them and keeping them connected: when one connection breaks, a text quietly stops going out.

MY TEXTS, WORD FOR WORD

These are the texts my clients get, copied from my system with my links taken out. Fill in the brackets and make them sound like you.

1. Request received. The moment the form comes in.

> Hey [first name], your custom tattoo request has been received!
>
> Your request is officially in my queue and I'll be reviewing it shortly. In the meantime, feel free to check out my reviews here 👉 [your Google reviews link]
>
> They'll give you a feel for the kind of experience I aim to provide my clients. I look forward to checking out your idea!
>
> If I don't need any additional information from you upon review, you'll receive a booking link shortly to move forward.
>
> [your name]

2. Approved, with the booking link. When I tag the request.

> Hey [first name], it's [your name]! I just went over your custom tattoo request and I would love to get this one done for you.
>
> My current rate, estimated price range, and current availability are all laid out in the private booking page I've linked below 👇🏻
>
> Final step is to grab a date here: [your booking link]
>
> I look forward to working with you, and thanks again for your trust!

3. First check-in. Day 2, if they haven't booked.

> Hope you're doing well! Did you get a chance to check out the info I sent you the other day?
>
> If you have any questions, don't hesitate to ask!

4. Last check-in. Around day 7.

> Hey [first name], just checking in one last time before I archive your request! Did you end up finding a date that works for you?
>
> Here's the link one more time in case you need it: [your booking link]
>
> If you have any questions or need help booking feel free to text me here anytime, and if now isn't a good time you can just resubmit your request whenever you're ready 👍🏻
>
> [your name]

5. Booked. The moment the deposit is paid.

> Thank you [first name], your tattoo session is booked!
>
> You can find important information about your appointment here: [your prep page]
>
> A reminder text with my suite address will be sent 24 hours before your session.
>
> I'll see you on [date and time]!

6. The day before.

> Here's a reminder for your tattoo session tomorrow at [time]!
>
> How to prepare for your session: [your prep page]
>
> Feel free to fill out this consent form before you arrive: [your consent form link]
>
> LOCATION: [studio name], [street address and suite], [city, state, ZIP]
>
> Please take a seat in the lobby and text me when you arrive!
>
> See you tomorrow 👍🏻

7. Aftercare and the review ask. After the session.

> [first name], thanks for coming!
>
> Here are your aftercare instructions: [your aftercare page]
>
> You don't have to worry about anything until tomorrow, then just follow the instructions from there... If you have a minute, it'd mean a lot if you left a quick Google review about your session!
>
> [your Google review link]
>
> Thanks again and hope to see you soon!
>
> [your name]

8. Birthday. Every year.

> Happy birthday from your tattoo artist, [first name]! 🎂
>
> I think it's time for a birthday tattoo... so here's my gift to you: $50 off your next one, any size, when you book in the next 30 days.
>
> Reply BIRTHDAY and I'll get you set up.
>
> Have a great one!
>
> [your name]

My deposit policy. On my booking page and in every booking.

> Deposits are non-refundable but they hold your spot, and I'll work with you to reschedule.

OR HAVE IT BUILT FOR YOU

Everything in this guide runs in my studio from one place. I call it the Private Studio System, and I'm opening a done-for-you version to a small group of artists first.

- **Built for you.** Your request form, booking calendar, deposits and every text, set up for your studio and written in your voice.
- **Software included.** One account with everything in this guide under one roof, so there are no separate form, texting, email or automation apps to connect.
- **One monthly payment.**
- **Ad management, if you want it.** I can run the Meta ads that send people to your request form, the same way I run mine: a submitted request is the only result that counts.

Prices are set at launch, and the list hears them first. You're already on it because you downloaded this guide. If you'd like a founding spot held, reply to the email this guide came with.

And if you'd rather build it yourself, everything you need is above. Either way, I hope it gets your next request booked.